

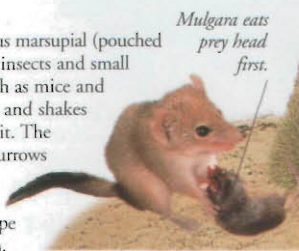
AUSTRALIAN WILDLIFE



AUSTRALIA HAS BEEN ISOLATED by water for more than 30 million years, resulting in the evolution of many unique animals and plants. Half of all marsupials, such as the koala and kangaroo, live only in Australia, along with the platypus and echidna, the world's only egg-laying mammals, or monotremes. Much of Australia is desert or scrub. The animals and plants that live here are adapted to the hot, dry conditions. There are also areas of tropical and temperate forests, which contain the greatest diversity of life in Australia.

Mulgara

This carnivorous marsupial (pouched mammal) eats insects and small vertebrates, such as mice and lizards. It bites and shakes its prey to kill it. The mulgara digs burrows in sand, in which it shelters to escape the midday sun.



Mulgara eats prey head first.

Porcupine grass

As its name suggests, porcupine grass is a spiny plant that grows in circular tussocks. It is adapted to dry desert conditions by having a thick outer covering (cuticle) to reduce water loss, and by having deep roots to reach water in the soil.

Emu

Emus are large flightless birds that can run at up to 50 kmh (30 mph), although they usually walk. They cover large distances in search of grasses, fruit, and flowers. They also eat insects. Males incubate the eggs and guard the young after they hatch.



Grass forms a refuge for insects, lizards, and birds.

Long, strong legs

Lizard searches for ants.

Galah

The galah, or roseate cockatoo, is one of the most common parrots in Australia. Large flocks of these birds are found not only in dry areas but also in cities. Galahs eat seeds, leaf buds, and insects.



Strong bill is used to dig up insects.

Thorny devil

This lizard's scales are drawn out into long spines. When temperatures fall at night, valuable water condenses on the spines and runs down tiny grooves towards the mouth.

Spines protect against predators.



Scrub and grassland wildlife

Covering about a third of Australia, scrub and grassland are hot and dry in summer and cooler in winter. Occasional downpours of rain are exploited by plants that rapidly bloom and produce seeds, and animals, such as frogs, that emerge to reproduce.

Short-beaked echidna

The short-beaked echidna is an egg-laying mammal found in Australia, Tasmania, and New Guinea. It uses its sticky tongue to extract ants and termites from their nests. If threatened, the echidna rolls into a ball, or digs down into the soil.

Male checks mound temperature with his beak, and by moving vegetation.

Mallee fowl

The male mallee fowl builds a mound of vegetation and soil in which the female lays her eggs. As the vegetation rots, it releases heat that incubates the eggs.



Canopy provides shelter for animals from the midday heat.



Water is stored in bulbous trunk.

Water-holding frog

This frog survives drought by burrowing into the ground, and forming a thin layer of skin around itself to conserve water. It also stores water in its bladder.



Bottle tree

These large trees get their name from their bottle-shaped trunks. The swollen trunk stores water that helps the tree survive periods of drought. The tree also provides food for many animals, including insects, and shelter for some birds and mammals. Other vegetation common in scrubland includes dry grasses and dwarf eucalyptus.

Kultarr

This small, mouse-like marsupial is nocturnal. It has large eyes to help it see in the dark, and to catch insects and spiders. It moves by springing off its long hind feet and tail and landing on its front feet. During the day the kultarr shelters in logs, hollow stumps, and burrows.

Kultarr feeding on a spider.

